ridden over 700 miles in six days. Normally the caravanserais lining the military road from Teheran to the shrine city of Mashhad on the Afghan border contained ample post-horses for travellers on official business. But the Shah of Persia was on his way to besiege Herat, and such was the volume of couriers passing between the camp and court that Rawlinson had been unable to change his mount for the entire journey.

Now, both his party and their horses were, as Rawlinson put it, ‘pretty knocked up, and in the dark, between sleeping and waking, we had managed to lose the road’. It was at this point, just as dawn was breaking over the jagged rim of the Kuh-e-Shah Jahan mountains, that Rawlinson saw another party of horsemen riding down on them through the half-light. ‘I was not anxious to accost these strangers,’ Rawlinson later reported, ‘but on cantering past them, I saw, to my astonishment, men in Cossack dresses, and one of my attendants recognised among the party, a servant of the Russian mission.’[2]

Rawlinson knew immediately he had stumbled on to something. There was no good reason for a party of armed Cossacks to be on these remote desert tracks heading for the Afghan frontier, and at this particular moment there was every reason for a British intelligence officer to be suspicious of any Russian activity in these crucial border marches. Rawlinson had been recruited from his regiment in India to the new intelligence corps and sent to Persia specifically to try to counteract growing Russian influence there. He had been in the country three years, training the Persian army and providing them with large quantities of British arms, as part of a calculated strategy to win back Persia into the British fold.

Within a few months of their arrival, Rawlinson and his party had realised they were being closely watched by the Russians. ‘A Russian officer, an aide de camp of Baron Von Rosen [the Russian Viceroy of the Caucasus], arrived in camp today,’ Rawlinson had reported in October 1834. ‘He was despatched by his General to pay his respects to the Ameer. His real object of course is to ascertain our position with the army, the state of the Persian troops, and such other objects as may fall under his observation affecting the interests of his country.’[3]

The cold war between Russia and Britain in 1830s Persia had turned particularly chilly in March 1833 with the arrival in Teheran of the suave Count Ivan Simonitch. Like the French officers who had come to the court of Ranjit Singh, Simonitch was a Napoleonic veteran who was looking for